

Survey design checklist

Open this beside your half-built form. Work down it before you send the survey to anybody.

Before you write a question

- ☐ One sentence saying what the survey is for. If you cannot write it, do not build the form.
- ☐ Every question earns its place by answering that sentence. Delete the rest.
- ☐ Decide now how you will analyse each answer. A question you cannot analyse is a question you cannot use.

Who you ask

- ☐ Say who your population is, exactly. 'Students' is not a population.
- ☐ Say how you reached them, and name it: convenience, snowball, random, stratified.
- ☐ Write down who your method leaves out. Every method leaves someone out.
- ☐ Decide your target number before you start, not after the responses stop.

Question order

- ☐ Easy and factual first. Age and income near the end, never at the start.
- ☐ Group questions by topic. Jumping between topics loses people.
- ☐ Sensitive questions last, so abandoning the form still leaves you usable data.
- ☐ Nothing earlier in the form should teach the respondent the answer to something later.

Writing a question

- ☐ One thing per question. 'Fast and reliable?' is two questions.
- ☐ No leading words. 'How good was...' assumes it was good.
- ☐ No jargon and no abbreviations your respondent would not use themselves.
- ☐ Every closed question needs an escape: 'Other', 'Prefer not to say', or 'Not applicable'.
- ☐ Check that answer options do not overlap and do cover everything.

Likert scales

- ☐ Pick one scale and use it for the whole section. Mixing 5-point and 7-point invalidates comparison.
- ☐ Label every point, not just the two ends.
- ☐ Decide whether to include a middle point, and say why in your method.
- ☐ Keep the direction the same throughout, or your reversed items will be scored backwards.
- ☐ It is ordinal data. Report the median and the spread; justify any mean you report.

Consent and ethics

- ☐ A consent line at the top: who you are, what it is for, how long it takes.
- ☐ Say whether it is anonymous. If you collect email addresses, it is not.
- ☐ Say what happens to the data and when it is deleted.
- ☐ Make participation clearly voluntary, and say they can stop at any point.
- ☐ If your university requires ethics approval, get it before you collect anything.

Pilot it

- ☐ Give it to five people who are not in your group.
- ☐ Time them. If it takes longer than you said, fix the form, not the claim.
- ☐ Ask each one which question confused them. Something always does.
- ☐ Export the pilot responses and try your actual analysis on them.
- ☐ Fix the form, then delete the pilot responses before you go live.

Before you send it

- ☐ Test the form on a phone. Most of your responses will come from one.
- ☐ Check required questions are the ones you meant to make required.
- ☐ Check the export: one row per response, one column per question.
- ☐ Keep a copy of the final questionnaire for your appendix.